

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 12 — “The Cost of Walking Alone”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone ash.

Approx. 26 pages.

ARC 1 FINALE

PAGE 1

Panels: 3 (silent opening)

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top)

The ruins camp in the aftermath. The scattered ash and broken stone where the colossus fell. The thirty-three souls who stood are returning to camp, exhausted but alive. The ten who stayed behind watch them in silence.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, center)

The BOY runs to the WOMAN IN RED. She drops her broken stone and holds him.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

BORCHU sits heavily against a wall, weapon across his lap, breathing hard. Not from exertion — the dead do not tire. From the weight of what they just did.

No dialogue.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4

Panel 1

ARGHUN writes frantically, ink-stained fingers trembling.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

SURO cleans ash from his sword with a scrap of cloth, movements precise and calm.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS stands apart from the others, staring at the horizon where the Former Rival had been. Now empty.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

Close on EGRIS's left arm — the Reaper's Mark has GROWN. It now covers his entire forearm, black

veins reaching toward his elbow. The skin around it is pale, lifeless.
No dialogue.

PAGE 3

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SURO approaches, sensing something wrong.
SURO: "Egris."

Panel 2

EGRIS quickly lowers his arm, hiding the mark.
EGRIS: "What?"

Panel 3

SURO tilts his blindfolded head.
SURO: "You are hurt."

PAGE 4

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "I am fine."

Panel 2

SURO: "That is a lie."

Panel 3

EGRIS says nothing.
No dialogue.

Panel 4

SURO: "The mark is spreading."

PAGE 5

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS: "It does not matter."

Panel 2

SURO: "It will. Soon."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Then I will deal with it when it does."

PAGE 6

Panels: 4

Panel 1

SURO, quieter.

SURO: "You cannot refuse Death the way you refused the others."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "I am not trying to."

Panel 3

SURO: "Then what are you doing?"

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Walking forward. Until I cannot."

PAGE 7

Panels: 3

Panel 1

Before Suro can respond, the air CHANGES. The cold fires go out. The whispers stop.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Every soul in the camp goes STILL.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

BORCHU rises, gripping his weapon.

BORCHU: "Not again—"

PAGE 8

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top)

But this time, no gates open. No armies descend. No colossus emerges.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

She simply APPEARS. The REAPER, standing in the center of the camp as if she had always been there.

Long severe black funeral robes. Long locs utterly still. Snake-slit pupils watching Egris.

No dialogue.

PAGE 9

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the Reaper has arrived)

The camp RECOILS. Some souls back away. Others freeze. The woman pulls the boy behind her. Borchu raises his weapon uselessly. Only EGRIS and SURO remain where they are.

The Reaper does not acknowledge anyone but Egris.

SFX: ... (total silence)

PAGE 10

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "I am not ready."

Panel 2

The REAPER, calm, patient.

REAPER: "I am not here for that."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Then why?"

Panel 4

REAPER: "To show you what you have built."

PAGE 11

Panels: 3

Panel 1

She gestures — a small, elegant motion of her hand — toward the camp. Toward the souls. No dialogue.

Panel 2

REAPER: "Forty-three. More arrive each day. Word spreads. A place where the dead are not commanded. Where they are not owned."

Panel 3

REAPER: "You did not mean to build this. But you did."

PAGE 12

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "I built nothing. They chose to come."

Panel 2

REAPER: "Because you refused to rule them. That refusal gave them something to choose."

Panel 3

REAPER: "Do you understand what that means?"

Panel 4

EGRIS: "No."

PAGE 13**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The REAPER steps closer. The camp holds its breath.

REAPER: "It means you have created the third path."

Panel 2

REAPER: "Not Heaven's order. Not Hell's chaos. Something else. Something that has never existed in the Wastes before."

Panel 3

REAPER: "And now everyone knows."

PAGE 14**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "I do not want—"

Panel 2

REAPER: "It does not matter what you want. It is done."

Panel 3

REAPER: "Heaven sees a rebellion. Hell sees a missed opportunity. The Wastes see a wound in their emptiness."

Panel 4

REAPER: "They will all come for you, Egris. Not to offer. To END."

PAGE 15**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "Then let them come."

Panel 2

The REAPER tilts her head, snake-eyes unblinking.

REAPER: "You say that as if you believe you will survive."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "I do not need to survive. I need to stand long enough for them to choose."

PAGE 16

Panels: 3

Panel 1

REAPER: "And when you fall?"

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Someone else will stand."

Panel 3

The REAPER is silent for a long moment. Then something changes in her expression — not quite a smile, but close.

REAPER: "You really believe that."

PAGE 17

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "Yes."

Panel 2

REAPER: "Then you are either the bravest man I have ever met, or the most foolish."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Can I not be both?"

Panel 4

The REAPER's mouth curves. It IS a smile now — small, cold, but real.

REAPER: "Yes."

PAGE 18

Panels: 3

Panel 1

She reaches out and touches EGRIS's left arm — directly over the Mark. Her fingers are cold. Absolute. No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS grimaces. The Mark FLARES — black veins burning under his skin.

SFX: thd thd thd

Panel 3

Then it STOPS. The pain fades. The Mark is still there, but it has stopped spreading. No dialogue.

PAGE 19

Panels: 4

Panel 1

The REAPER withdraws her hand.

REAPER: "You have time. Not much. But some."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Why?"

Panel 3

REAPER: "Because I want to see how this ends."

Panel 4

REAPER: "I have watched empires rise and fall. I have watched gods demand worship and be forgotten. But I have never watched a man refuse everything and still stand."

PAGE 20**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

REAPER: "Do not mistake this for mercy, Egris. I am not saving you. I am giving you enough rope to see whether you hang yourself or build a ladder."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "And when my time runs out?"

Panel 3

REAPER: "Then I will take what is owed. And we will see if your choices mattered."

PAGE 21**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top)

The REAPER turns to leave — then pauses, looking back at him one last time.

REAPER: "One more thing."

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

REAPER: "The Former Rival is gathering an army. Not of echoes. Of the living dead who believe in his vision of order."

PAGE 22**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

REAPER: "He will return. And when he does, he will not ask you to join him."

Panel 2

REAPER: "He will try to destroy you. To prove that your way cannot work."

Panel 3

REAPER: "Are you prepared for that?"

Panel 4

EGRIS: "No."

PAGE 23**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

REAPER: "Good. Certainty is the first step toward tyranny."

Panel 2

She turns and walks into the mist. Within three steps, she is GONE — as if she had never been.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

The camp slowly breathes again. The fires reignite. Whispers return.
No dialogue.

PAGE 24**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

BORCHU approaches EGRIS, weapon still raised.
BORCHU: "What did she want?"

Panel 2

EGRIS, looking at his marked arm.
EGRIS: "To warn me. And to give me a choice."

Panel 3

BORCHU: "What choice?"

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Keep walking. Or stop before it costs me everything."

PAGE 25**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

BORCHU: "And?"

Panel 2

EGRIS looks up at the camp. At the forty-three souls. At SURO. At the WOMAN and the BOY. At ARGHUN still writing. At the broken soldiers and frightened farmers who chose to stand.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS: "I keep walking."

PAGE 26

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — ARC 1 closing image)

Wide shot from above: the ruins camp small against the endless Wastes. The pale sky. The broken pillars. The forty-three souls scattered throughout, returning to their routines. EGRIS at the camp's edge, spear in hand, watching the horizon.

In the far distance, barely visible: another camp forming. Fires. Shapes moving in formation. The FORMER RIVAL's army, gathering.

Two paths. Two visions. And the Wastes waiting to see which one survives.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): He had refused Heaven's throne, Hell's crown, and an army of the dead. He had walked a path no one had walked before. And now, standing at the edge of the Wastes with Death's mark on his arm and an enemy rising on the horizon, Egris faced the only question that mattered: How long can a man stand alone before the world breaks him? Or before he becomes what he swore never to be?

— **END OF CHAPTER 12** —

— **END OF ARC 1: THE REFUSAL** —

To Be Continued in Arc 2...

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **The Reaper's second appearance** — she is NOT threatening this time. She is CURIOUS. Her smile (Page 17) is genuine — she is entertained by Egris, fascinated by what he's attempting.
- **The Mark (Page 18)** — when she touches it, show it FLARE violently, then STOP spreading. It's still there, still dangerous, but frozen at the forearm. This is her gift: time.
- **Page 26 (final splash)** — this must show SCALE and THREAT. The Former Rival's army should be visible as a distant gathering force. Not detailed, just enough to show: something is coming.
- **Tone:** Bittersweet victory. Arc 1 ends with Egris having refused everything and stood his ground — but the cost is becoming clear. The Mark. The gathering army. The Reaper watching. He's won the battle but the war is just beginning.
- **Final narration** — this is the Arc thesis statement AND the Arc 2 setup. It should feel like both an ending and a beginning.